

Study Guide

This study guide provides a comprehensive overview of the short story “Sujan Bhagat,” authored by the renowned writer Munshi Premchand. It is designed to assist students and readers in understanding the narrative’s themes, characters, and moral implications, specifically within the context of the Karnataka Second PUC Hindi curriculum, “Sahitya Gaurav.”

Key Concepts and Narrative Summary

Author Profile: Munshi Premchand (1880–1936)

- **Original Name:** Dhanpat Rai.
- **Urdu Pen Name:** Nawab Rai.
- **Title:** Known as “Upanyas Samrat” (The Emperor of Novels).
- **Significance:** A premier figure in Indian literature, his works often explore social realism and the life of the common man.

Plot Overview

The story “Sujan Bhagat” centers on **Sujan Mahto**, a diligent farmer who achieves wealth and social prestige through sheer hard work. His life takes a turn following a pilgrimage to **Gaya**, after which he adopts the title “Sujan Bhagat” and shifts his focus toward religious devotion and prayer (*bhajan-puja*).

As Sujan abandons active farming to pursue a life of piety, he loses his authority within his own household. Control shifts to his wife, **Bulaki**, and his sons. Despite gaining respect in the village for his religious devotion, his status within his home diminishes significantly. After experiencing several humiliations, Sujan realizes that idle devotion does not command true respect. He returns to his rigorous labor and, through approximately eight months of intense work, successfully regains his lost authority and honor.

Core Themes and Message

Theme	Description
Dharma vs. Karma	The story emphasizes that religious devotion (<i>Dharma</i>) should not replace one’s duty and labor (<i>Karma</i>). Both must coexist.

Theme	Description
The Value of Labor	True respect and rights are earned through hard work and productivity, not merely through the outward display of piety.
Household Power Dynamics	Explores how economic contribution and active participation dictate authority within a family structure.

Short-Answer Practice Questions

- 1. Who is the author of “Sujan Bhagat,” and what was his original name? * Answer:** The author is Munshi Premchand; his original name was Dhanpat Rai.
- 2. By what famous title is Premchand known in the literary world? * Answer:** He is known as “Upanyas Samrat” (The Emperor of Novels).
- 3. What transformation did Sujan Mahto undergo after his pilgrimage to Gaya? * Answer:** He began to be called “Sujan Bhagat” and became deeply immersed in religious devotion (*bhajan-puja*), eventually leaving his farming responsibilities.
- 4. How did Sujan’s shift toward a religious life affect his status at home? * Answer:** His authority in the house decreased as power shifted to his wife, Bulaki, and his sons. While his respect increased in the village, it diminished within his family.
- 5. How long did it take for Sujan to regain his honor, and how did he do it? * Answer:** It took approximately eight months of returning to hard physical labor for Sujan to regain his lost rights and respect.

Essay Questions for Deeper Exploration

1. The Interplay of Respect and Responsibility

Analyze the irony of Sujan Bhagat’s social standing. How is it possible for a character to gain “respect” in the village while losing it within his own home? Discuss the author’s critique of “idle devotion” versus active contribution to the family and society.

2. The Conflict of Household Authority

Discuss the shift of power from Sujan to Bulaki and their sons. In the context of the story, is authority tied to age and seniority, or is it tied to labor and economic utility? Use specific instances from the text to support your argument.

3. The Central Message: “Dharma and Karma”

The story concludes that “true honor and rights are obtained through hard work, not just the show of devotion.” Evaluate this message. How does Premchand use Sujan’s journey to argue that religion and duty should move forward together?

Glossary of Important Terms

Term	Definition
Upanyas Samrat	A title meaning “Emperor of Novels,” used to describe Munshi Premchand’s dominance in Indian fiction.
Bhagat	A title for a devotee or a pious person; in the story, Sujan Mahto becomes Sujan Bhagat.
Gaya	A significant pilgrimage site mentioned in the story that triggers Sujan’s religious transformation.
Sahitya Gaurav	The name of the Hindi textbook for Karnataka Second PUC, in which this story is the first prose lesson.
Bulaki	The wife of Sujan Mahto, who takes over household authority during his period of inactivity.
Nawab Rai	The pseudonym Munshi Premchand used when he originally wrote in the Urdu language.
Bhajan-Puja	Religious songs and worship; the activities that Sujan prioritized over his agricultural duties.